

THE
SACRED
HEART

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Current Religious Comment

ITEMS OF INTEREST TO CATHOLIC READERS IN THE MAGAZINES.

Books That Helped.

In the very readable and entertaining article which she contributes to the current *Catholic World* on the lamented Richard Malcolm Johnston, and in the portion thereof where she describes the manner of the late litterateur's conversion to Catholicism, Regina Armstrong says that there was much in that period of Mr. Johnston's life that was both beautiful and pathetic. The beautiful feature of it was the deceased author's knowledge that his acceptance of his wife's faith—Mrs. Johnston became a convert years in advance of her husband—would bring comfort and joy to her, and his desire to afford her that pleasure and consolation if he could conscientiously do so. The pathetic part lay in the sundering of many relations that were naturally dear to him. It appears that it was the Native-American fanaticism of nearly half a century ago which set Johnston to studying the Catholic Church. Being desirous of combating the atrocious attacks, which he instinctively felt to be false, then made upon the Church, he began reading Catholic books, the better to acquaint himself with the history, faith and teachings of the Church. Bishop England's works were the first which he consulted, and they, so this writer tells us, not only furnished him with arguments to refute the Know-nothing diatribes, but also removed many of the prejudices against Catholicism which he had himself entertained previously. Then he took up Newman's "Justification" of his conversion, in reply to Mr. Gladstone, and that work carried him still farther on the road to Rome. He tried to arrest his own progress by reading Laud and Hooker; but those Anglican authorities no longer convinced him. His actual conversion came about in this way, to use the description this paper gives us of it: "He relates that he was sitting out under the chestnut trees on his lawn reading Balmes, when the decision came to him with overwhelming force. The struggles, indecisions and waverings of years had been brushed away by the wings of faith on which his soul must evermore rest. To his wife he said simply, 'I am going with you, my dear.' This was in 1875." Colonel Johnston never wavered in his new-found faith, once he had embraced it; and he lived long enough after his conversion to see much of the prejudice concerning the Church that existed in the South half a century ago fade away.

Bismarck and Leo XIII.

Sidney Whitman contributes a paper on Bismarck to the November *Harper's Monthly*, and in one part of it he gives us Bismarck's opinion of Leo XIII., as the grim chancellor expressed it to Eugen Wolf, the well known traveler, who visited Bismarck at Frederichsruh in the latter years of his life. Herr Wolf had previously been in Rome, where he was received in audience by the Holy Father. As he was about leaving the papal presence the Sovereign Pontiff asked him whither he was next journeying, and when Herr Wolf told him that he contemplated going to Germany, and hoped while there to see Bismarck, the Pope exclaimed: "Il Principe di Bismarck! do not forget to greet him for me." When he reached Frederichsruh, Bismarck asked Herr Wolf whence he had come, and when the traveler replied from Rome, the ex-chancellor, after learning that he had seen the Pope, inquired after the health of his Holiness, and then added: "I must tell you that I always got on very well indeed with him. He even gave me his highest decoration, mounted in brilliants. It was only that confounded (verflixte) little excellency

(Windthorst) whom I could not manage to get along with." That declaration, which Bismarck undoubtedly intended to be a disparagement of Windthorst, will only serve to exalt the memory of "the Pearl of Meppen" in the minds of men who know for what excellent reasons he waged unrelenting war upon Chancellor Bismarck.

The Farallones.

Under the title of "Our Seaboard Islands on the Pacific," Mr. John E. Bennett contributes to this same magazine a very interesting and instructive paper dealing with the islands that lie off the Californian coast, and which are known as the Farallones. Of one of these islands, San Nicholas, he tells us that long before their discovery by Cabrillo, in 1542, this particular island was overrun by the Innuist Indians, who came down from the North, killed all the men, and carried off all things that they thought of any value, leaving only the women and children behind them. The original inhabitants of these islands are described by Cabrillo as a mild, but vigorous race. The women and children left on San Nicholas maintained themselves after the Innuist invasion, and the island again became peopled. In 1835 some Franciscan missionaries came to the island from California and persuaded the islanders to remove to the mainland and reside at the missions. When the boats had left the island one woman discovered that her child had been overlooked and left behind. She jumped from the boat and swam back to San Nicholas, where she and her child were then the only inhabitants. The child died soon afterwards, but the mother lived to an advanced age, and near the end of her days she was brought to the Santa Barbara mission, at which her death took place.

A Mussulman's Ideas.

Whenever all other pleas in justification of John Bull's land-grabbing policy, which is continually asserting itself, fail, the claim is made for him by his apologists that in extending British control over pagan lands, he is rendering Christianity good service. In other words, it is claimed that wherever the British government gains a foothold, heathenism is doomed, and the way opened for civilization and Christianity. That this claim is not by any means always good is very clearly proven by Rafiuddin Ahmad in the *Nineteenth Century*. This writer, who is himself a Mussulman, declares that were it not for British rule and the British government Mohammedanism would be a far weaker influence in India and other lands than it is today. He asserts that Great Britain gives Mohammedans enormous assistance by allowing them to preach and propagate their creed, by voice and writing, without hindrance. And lest it be inferred that John Bull's attitude towards this pagan creed be one of passive submission and non-interference, we are, furthermore, informed that under British auspices, the first Mussulman university to come into existence is about to be established in India. This Mohammedan writer enumerates a number of other benefits which British rule has conferred upon Mohammedanism, and he does not hesitate to affirm that whatever influence this form of paganism exercises now, and will hereafter exercise in India, is and will continue to be, due to the help and assistance which it receives from Great Britain.

A Shameful Story.

In these days, when so many Americans are complacently, though perhaps all unwarrantably, priding themselves upon their belief that this country is in every sense superior to its late antagonist, unfortunate Spain, it may not be amiss to recall to public attention the shameful story of our dealings with our own aborigines, the Indians of America. Those desirous of reading that

story may find it told very fairly and well in the paper, "The Indians as They Are," which Charles Carson contributes to the November *Catholic World*. Mr. Carson, who bases his article largely upon the recently-published report of the Commissioner of Indian Affairs, does not mince his words. He declares—and who can gainsay him?—that "the policy of our government towards the Indians has been one of greed, outrage and dishonor. As a race the Indian has been systematically robbed and degraded, until now he is as a worm under the heel of the Anglo-Saxon." The latter word may not be the exact term, but Mr. Carson is probably one of those individuals who hold that all Americans are Anglo-Saxons. "While we justly challenge Spain for the barbarous and inhuman treatment of the Cubans," says he again, "we ourselves are committing the same crime against the American Indians, and even more cruel, relentless and complete. All those broad lands that constitute our country, those millions of acres stretching from ocean to ocean, were bought with the life-blood of the red men." "Too late the American people," he tells us in another passage, "will awaken to the fact that the Indians have suffered wrongs at their hands. When they realize the full extent of their error, and how great has been the distress caused by it to the Indians; when the true history of this unfortunate people is known, it will confound those who love their country and cause them to turn away in shame and confusion." And he adds that our treatment of the Indians is a passage which justice must blush to read.

Help the Catholic Indian Missions.

Mr. Carson writes his paper principally to enlist sympathy and assistance for the Catholic Indian missions and schools, which, he says, are the only agencies capable of doing good for these unfortunate people. Consistently with its past record the government now refuses to aid the Indians through these institutions which alone have demonstrated the desire and the ability to befriend the aborigines. In consequence, many of the missions and schools are in a very precarious condition, and all of them are crippled in their energies. Were there less sectarian animosity and jealousy than, unhappily, exist in this country, especially when Indian appropriations are mentioned, we might hope for a generous response to the appeal which this writer makes when he says: "The American people are famed for generosity; there never was yet a nation stricken by famine or in distress that called in vain for aid. . . . If the cause of humanity enlists our sympathy so that we undertake a war, sacrificing countless lives and millions of money, in behalf of Cuban revolutionists, who have no claim at all upon this country, how much more should our compassion be extended to the Indians, for whose misery we are responsible." American Catholics should at least see that the Catholic Indian missions and schools be not forced for lack of support to cease their beneficent work. For, as Mr. Carson says, these missions and schools are permanent bases of operation for the Indian missionaries; and he well adds that not only Catholics, but all who are Christians and friends of justice, should awaken to the fact that it is not only charity, but a duty to second the efforts of these missionaries who are endeavoring, at great self-sacrifice, to save the remnants of our aboriginal races and to atone for the monstrous wrongs which the government has inflicted upon them.

GENERAL WEYLER might take a grim satisfaction in hearing from Cuba that there is almost as much starvation in that unhappy island at the present time as there was in the days of the reconcentrados.

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